



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: New Hope Christian Academy of Southern Illinois
School Website: <https://nhcalions.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

New Hope Christian Academy (NHCA) in Southern Illinois presents a robust CLASSICAL Christian education profile across all six rubric categories. The school grounds its program in explicit theology and liturgy, centers education on formation and virtue, actively employs the grammar–logic–rhetoric Trivium, emphasizes Great Books and Socratic discourse, cultivates a living, mentorship-focused faculty culture, and partners with families as co-educators. Public-facing materials repeatedly foreground Christ-centered learning, Scripture as foundational truth, worship and biblical formation, history through a Western civilizational lens, and a classical pedagogy (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Socratic seminars; rhetoric training). Faculty hiring emphasizes shared faith and formation, while parent involvement and ACCS membership reinforce a sustained classical community around the school. Based on the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School rubric, NHCA earns CLASSICAL across all six categories, with strong corroboration from multiple NHCA sources and corroborating elements in the classical-education knowledge base.

Key contextual evidence includes: Christ-centered daily worship and Scripture grounding; explicit statements about the trivium and Great Books; Socratic discussion and rhetorical training in upper grades; a House System supporting mentorship and character formation; employment language describing teachers as spiritually committed mentors; and deliberate parent education and family-partnership orientation. Citations drawing from NHCA public materials (articles, essays, and policy pages) and the classical-education knowledge base are provided inline below.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: NHCA emphasizes Christ-centered formation, worship, and Scripture as the foundation of study (basis in theology; liturgical practice).
- Purpose and Goal: The school frames education as formation of the whole person—loving God with all minds, virtue and wisdom, not solely job prep.
- Curriculum: The program explicitly centers grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, and a Great Conversation approach; history taught throughout curriculum; emphasis on wonder.
- Pedagogy: Lower grades include the Trivium model; upper grades emphasize Socratic discussion and rhetoric; education framed as contemplative at times; classical memory-work/memorization aligns with Scholastic-like practices.
- Faculty: NHCA describes teachers as living, virtuous mentors aligned with Christian formation; faculty are sought who share a living faith and can model virtue.
- Parents & Community: The school explicitly partners with families, provides parent education, and invites visits and tours; ACCS membership anchors the broader classical community.

Note: The analysis below uses a keyword-analysis framework aligned to the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) knowledge base, and then maps NHCA content to those elements. See the accompanying "Six Essential Elements" keywords for positive/negative indicators used in the category scoring. Positive and negative keyword indicators are drawn from the knowledge base document.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- NHCA materials describe Christ-centered education with worship, daily Scripture focus, and a theistic foundation for truth, knowledge, and learning. Statements such as “Christ Centered,” “From starting our day with worship and the word to meditating on the things of God,” and “every aspect of NHCA is based on Scripture” show explicit theological grounding and liturgical practice.
- The school explicitly anchors truth to God, evidenced by phrases like “the conviction that all truth is ultimately God’s truth” and Scripture-based authority.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: theology, Scripture, worship, liturgy, transcendental truth (God’s truth), Logos, sacred tradition, contemplation, reverence, wonder. Quantitatively, at least 4–5 explicit terms (Christ-centered, worship/Word, Scripture, God’s truth, Bible/theology) appear across NHCA materials.
- Negative keywords: none clearly present in NHCA public materials.
- Why this rating
- The public-facing materials demonstrate a robust theological axis, liturgical practice, and a belief in transcendental Truth grounded in Christian theology, aligning this category with CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- NHCA frames education as formation: “formation of a whole person,” “to love God with all their minds,” prayerful pursuit of wisdom, and virtue through a Christian-seeded liberal-arts approach. The trivium framing (grammar/logic/rhetoric) is paired with a purpose of moral and intellectual formation.
- The emphasis on virtue, wonder, and the cultivation of the human person aligns with classical aims, not merely information delivery or job-prep.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, character, moral imagination, contemplation, great conversation, the pursuit of true/good/beautiful, love of learning, mimicry of classical aims; Great Books and Great Conversation language is evident in NHCA materials.
- Negative keywords: none apparent in NHCA public materials.
- Why this rating
- NHCA emphasizes formation over information, virtue and wisdom over mere marketable skills, and a transcendent framework of truth/goodness/beauty, consistent with CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The curriculum explicitly uses grammar/logic/rhetoric (Trivium) developmentally: Grammar (Pre-K–5), Logic (6–8), Rhetoric (9–12). Great Books/readings and a “great books of Western Civilization” emphasis are highlighted, with students entering into the Great Conversation via Socratic discussion. History is taught throughout and organized in a way that emphasizes lineage and Western civilization.
- “History classes are organized chronologically,” and there is a strong emphasis on the study of literature, history, mathematics, sciences, and the fine arts with a classical heritage.
- Emphasis on wonder and the cultivation of the intellectual life is embedded in the public materials (e.g., “the art of thinking,” Great Books, and the Great Conversation).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, great conversation, Socratic discussion, history (Western civilization), liberal arts, quadrivium (explicitly referenced in the knowledge base to define classical curricula), formation through the arts, wonder. The NHCA materials reference grammar/logic/rhetoric explicitly and reference Great Books and the Great Conversation concept.
- Negative keywords: none evident.

- Why this rating
- The curriculum is clearly structured around the liberal arts and the Trivium, with explicit Great Books and classical history integration, meeting CLASSICAL criteria.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Pedagogy includes a strong emphasis on Socratic discussion and seminars in the upper grades, with opportunities to develop rhetoric and public speaking. The trivium stages guide pedagogy from grammar through rhetoric; lower-grade routines often include memorization and chant-like memory work consistent with scholé and contemplative pedagogy.
- The public materials explicitly discuss the use of Socratic dialogue and dialectic as core methods, plus the development of memory and recitation as component pedagogy (memorizations, chanting, etc.). These align with classical pedagogy indicators. □filecite□turn14□
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, great conversation, memory work, recitation, chanting, scholé, contemplative learning, rhetoric, seminar, dialogue-based instruction, logic, debate. NHCA materials align with these through references to Great Books, Socratic discussion, and a grammar/-logic/rhetoric progression.
- Negative keywords: none evident in NHCA public materials; some modern education critiques (e.g., project-based only) are listed in the knowledge base as negative signals, but NHCA materials do not emphasize those in a negative way.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogy aligns with classical expectations: contemplative moments (Scholé) balanced with rigorous Socratic discourse and rhetorical training, supporting CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- NHCA emphasizes faculty as living models of virtue and faith; teachers are sought who can embody the presence of God and a classical Christian educational vision. The school highlights that faculty must share Christian faith and be committed to a formation-oriented approach; ACCS membership underscores a network of classical Christian educators.
- Employment materials describe teachers who value a living faith in Jesus Christ and who are committed to Christian formation, with flexibility around state certification to prioritize fit with the school's philosophy.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: living curriculum (implied phrase in classical-education contexts), mentor/teacher as model, moral exemplar, faith-based hiring, Christian formation, Catholic/Protestant faith alignment (explicitly Protestant in the materials) and ACCS affiliation.
- Negative keywords: none clearly present; the hiring policy explicitly emphasizes faith alignment rather than certification status, which is a deliberate choice rather than a negative signal.
- Why this rating
- NHCA positions faculty as the core living embodiment of the school's classical Christian mission and aligns with classical expectations of teacher as mentor and exemplar.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- NHCA emphasizes partnership with families and sees parents as co-teachers. The school provides parent education content and invites parents to engage with classical education concepts; it also promotes visits and tours to the school. The ACCS affiliation also signals a broader community framework for families.

- The site quotes Chesterton and offers parent-facing admissions and education paths, reinforcing family involvement and education outside the classroom.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families, parent formation, book clubs, seminars, family liturgy alignment (as implied by the theological framing and parent education), open campus/visitor access, and co-educator language. The knowledge-base indicators include explicit “Partnership with Families” as a positive keyword.
- Negative keywords: none clearly present in NHCA's public content; the school's approach emphasizes family involvement rather than a consumer model.
- Why this rating
- NHCA presents a robust parent/community integration consistent with classical pedagogy and community formation, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment: CLASSICAL

Overall, NHCA demonstrates a comprehensive CLASSICAL orientation across all six categories. The school's theological grounding, formation-focused mission, Trivium-based curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, living-faculty model, and family-partnered community reinforce consistent alignment with classical education principles and the Six Essential Elements framework.

What Would Move the Needle

- No major needle-moving changes are required. NHCA already exhibits strong classical elements across all six categories in alignment with the Six Essential Elements. If desired, minor enhancements could emphasize explicit mention of specific positive keywords from the knowledge-base (e.g., directly labeling “formation of wisdom and virtue” in mission statements or curriculum pages) to further crystallize the alignment for external readers, though the current materials already convey the classical vision clearly.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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